Cinematography: Shots

Framing of the Shot

Framing is the process by which the cinematographer or camera operator uses the boundaries and dimensions of the moving image to determine what we see on the screen. Framing involves composition and vice versa, so understanding where one concept ends and the other begins can be difficult. To understand what distinguishes framing, it helps to consider the term itself: *framing* directly engages the *frame*—the boundaries of the image, including the farthest visible depth and the fourth wall behind the lens—and how what we see and the way in which we see it is shaped by those borders. Framing turns the comparatively infinite sight of the human eye into a finite movie image—an unlimited view into a limited view. This process requires decisions about each of the following elements: the implied proximity to the camera of main subjects, the depth of the composition, the camera angle and height space within and outside of the frame, point of view, and the type of camera movement, if any.

To understand the relationship between framing and composition, it may be helpful to consider the work of a documentary cinematographer such as Kirsten Johnson. Watching her 2016 film *Cameraperson*, which is made up of footage she shot over the course of her long career, we see framing in action. She must continually position and move her camera to compose shots of real people and unrehearsed action. She uses framing to select what we see and composition to make the resulting images visually coherent and engaging.

***Cameraperson* (Kirsten Johnson, 2016)**

Aspect Ratio

The relationship between the frame's two dimensions is known as its aspect ratio, the ratio of the width of the image to its height. Almost all movies are made to be shown in one aspect ratio from beginning to end. The most common aspect ratios are:

(1.375:1) Academy (35mm flat)

(1.66:1) European widescreen (35mm flat)

(1.85:1) American widescreen (35mm flat)

(2.2:1) Super Panavision and Todd-AO (70mm flat)

(2.35:1) Panavision and CinemaScope (35mm anamorphic)

(2.75:1) Ultra Panavision (70mm anamorphic)

Figure 6.1 | BASIC ASPECT RATIOS

1.375:1

1.85:1

2.35:1

Although filmmakers seldom use more than one aspect ratio in a movie, in shooting *The Grand Budapest Hotel* (2014), director Wes Anderson differentiated scenes taking place in different time periods by shooting in three different aspect ratios. Scenes set in the 1930s are shot in the Academy 1.375:1 ratio in common use during that decade. Scenes taking place from 1985 to the present are in the 1.85:1 widescreen format, and action set in the 1960s is shot in the 2.35:1 widescreen ratio.

Masking

When a filmmaker wants to depict a subject or situation using a frame size and shape other than the one imposed by the chosen aspect ratio, she can also use setting, objects, or even characters to block off, or ***mask***, portions of the frame, thus creating a new frame or frames within the standard rectangle. In Mike Nichols's *The Graduate* (1967; cinematographer Robert Surtees), during her initial seduction scene of Ben Braddock (Dustin Hoffman), Mrs. Robinson (Anne Bancroft) sits at the bar in her house and raises one leg onto the stool next to her, forming a triangle through which Ben is framed or, perhaps, trapped.

***The Graduate* (Mike Nichols, 1967)**